

Deafness in Dogs and Cats

Types of deafness

Congenital (present at birth) — common in pets with white coats or certain color patterns (e.g., merle, piebald). Hearing cells in the inner ear stop working shortly after birth. Usually permanent.

Acquired (develops later)

- **Sensorineural** — damage to the inner-ear **hair cells** that turn sound into nerve signals. Causes: aging, illness or infection, injury, toxins or certain drugs. Usually permanent.
- **Conductive** — sound cannot travel through the ear canal, eardrum or middle ear. Causes: ear infection, wax, fluid, polyps or tumors. **Some forms are treatable.**

Signs at home

- Not responding to their name, doorbell or other sounds
- Sleeping through loud noises
- Startling when touched unexpectedly
- Barking or meowing more (they cannot hear themselves)

Testing

BAER (brainstem auditory evoked response) — measures the brain's electrical response to sound. Painless, but pets must be still, so sedation may be needed.

- **Can tell:** whether each ear hears or not, and at higher vs. lower sound levels

- **Cannot tell:** how well your pet hears, which frequencies, the cause, or whether hearing will return

MRI or CT of the head can look for something blocking sound or a problem in the ear:

- **MRI** — better for brain, nerves and soft tissue; recommended if there are other neurological signs (e.g., balance problems)
- **CT** — better for bone and detailed ear structures

Living with a deaf pet

Safety

- Leash or fenced area outdoors at all times
- ID tag or microchip noting your pet is deaf; consider a locating (GPS) device
- Avoid startling — approach where they can see you, or let them feel footsteps

Communication and training

- Hand signals and visual cues; reward with treats (positive reinforcement)
- Stomp on the floor (vibration) or flick a light to get attention
- Use a gentle, consistent touch as a signal
- Consider a trainer experienced with deaf pets

Quality of life

Deaf dogs and cats can live **normal, happy lives**. They often rely more on sight and smell. Deafness does not affect intelligence or their ability to be loving, well-behaved companions.